

These thought leaders also believed in the primacy of the nation-state and the liberty of human beings, exemplified by two of Thomas Paine's powerful and influential tracts, *The Age of Reason* and *The Rights of Man*. Paine's impassioned essay *Common Sense* played an important role in the founding of our nation, helping to awaken the American colonists to the understanding of the absurdity "in supposing a continent can be perpetually governed by an island," to the need for "a government that contained the greatest sum of individual happiness with the least national expense," and to the understanding that "the more simple anything is, the less liable it is to be disordered."²²

Like Paine, Thomas Jefferson and Alexander Hamilton spoke eloquently of reason, rights, and reform. The correspondence of John Adams, George Washington, James Madison, and others among our Founding Fathers is punctuated with the values of the Enlightenment. These men were strongly influenced by its proponents in Great Britain and throughout Europe, a "who's who" of the era, including Edmund Burke, David Hume, Immanuel Kant, John Locke, Sir Isaac Newton, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and Adam Smith.

The ideas of those philosophers sprang, in turn, from their predecessors of yore, another Hall of Fame that stretches from Homer, Sophocles, Socrates, Plato, Aristotle, and Virgil, to Dante, William Shakespeare, Sir Francis Bacon, and John Milton—all great thinkers and writers who expressed their ideas with a force and clarity that continues to impress us to this day. The eighteenth-century heroes of the Age of Reason stood on the shoulders of these earlier heroes, and it is hard to imagine our modern world without their contributions.²³

The Prototypical Eighteenth-Century Man

Perhaps the paradigm of the eighteenth-century man was Benjamin Franklin. I cite him here not only as a remarkable illustration of the